Good Plant

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Good Plant is an interactive installation that explores how human ideas of care and order can become a form of control over non-human life.

Video Link: https://vimeo.com/1223468844?share=copy&fl=sv&fe=ci
Github repo: https://github.com/XuanqiCHEN-8/DCT-Summer-Term-Final-Project

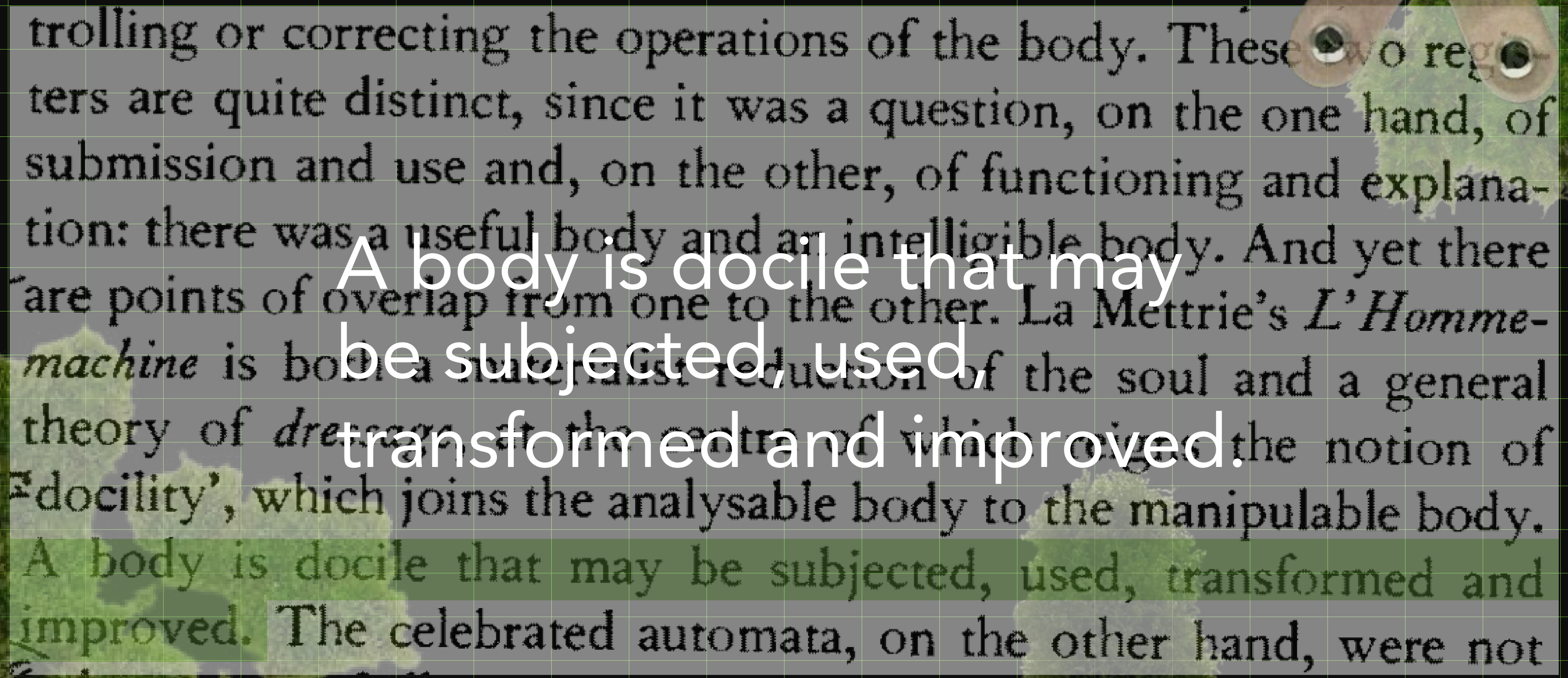
Introduction

Good Plant is an interactive installation that explores how human ideas of order and care can become forms of control over non-human life. Inspired by Foucault's concept of the "docile body," the work transforms a plant into a mechanical body whose movement is restricted by a predefined system. Visitors are invited to gently "groom" the plant with a comb, triggering its gradual movement from a bent position towards an upright, human-defined "correct" state. Through this seemingly caring interaction, the work questions who determines what is considered normal, healthy, or better for another living being.

Concept and Background Research

My interest in order started from observing how rules and patterns affect behaviour. In my first project, I explored how a simple rule could make people follow the same pattern. The work used many mouths. At first, all the mouths said "0". When one mouth was pressed, it changed to "1", and then all the other mouths also started to say "1". This made me think about how one action can create a shared rule and influence a group.
In my second project, I moved from human behaviour to animals. I used a pet leash and TouchDesigner to explore the relationship between humans and animals. The leash became a symbol of how humans guide, control and define the movement of another living being. These two projects made me interested in a wider question: how do human ideas of order affect non-human life?

Untilled - Pierre Huyghe

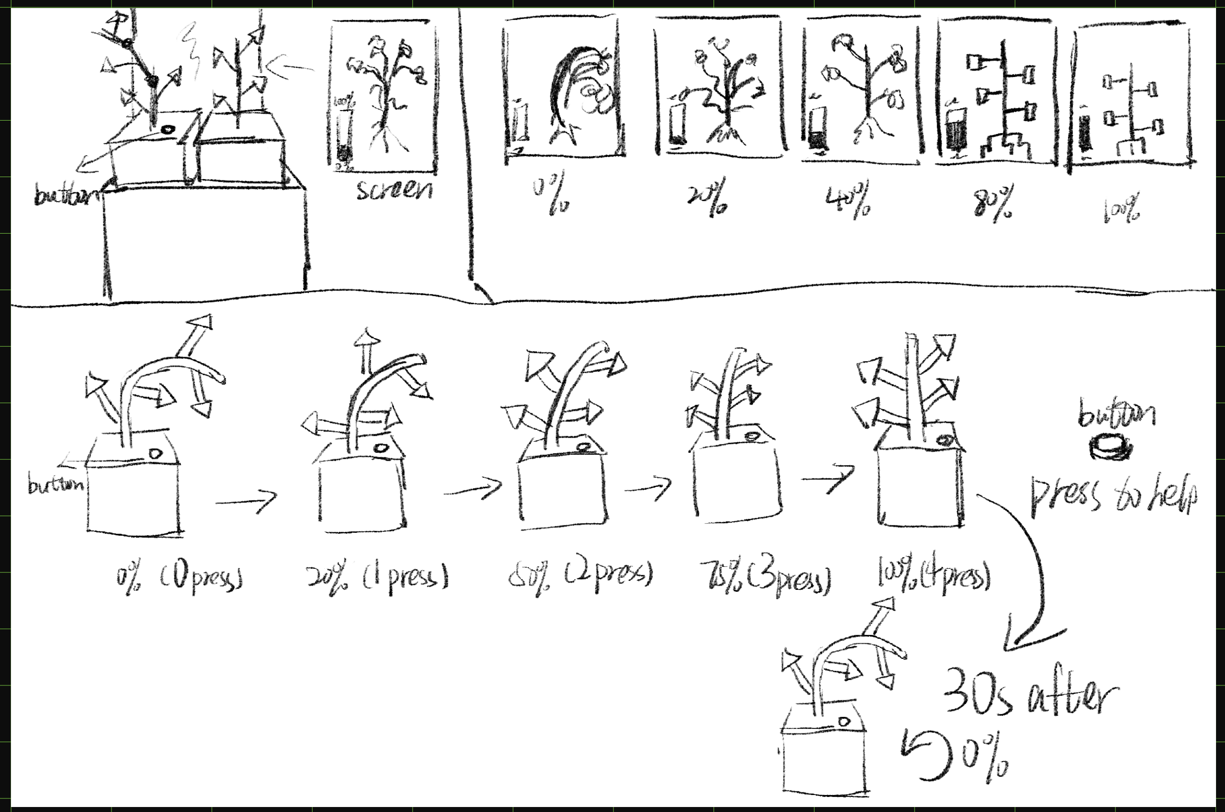

trolling or correcting the operations of the body. These two registers are quite distinct, since it was a question, on the one hand, of submission and use and, on the other, of functioning and explanation: there was a useful body and an intelligible body. And yet there are points of overlap from one to the other. La Mettrie's *L'Homme-machine* is bo[illegible] of the soul and a general theory of *dre*[illegible] the notion of 'docility', which joins the analysable body to the manipulable body. A body is docile that may be subjected, used, transformed and improved. The celebrated automata, on the other hand, were not

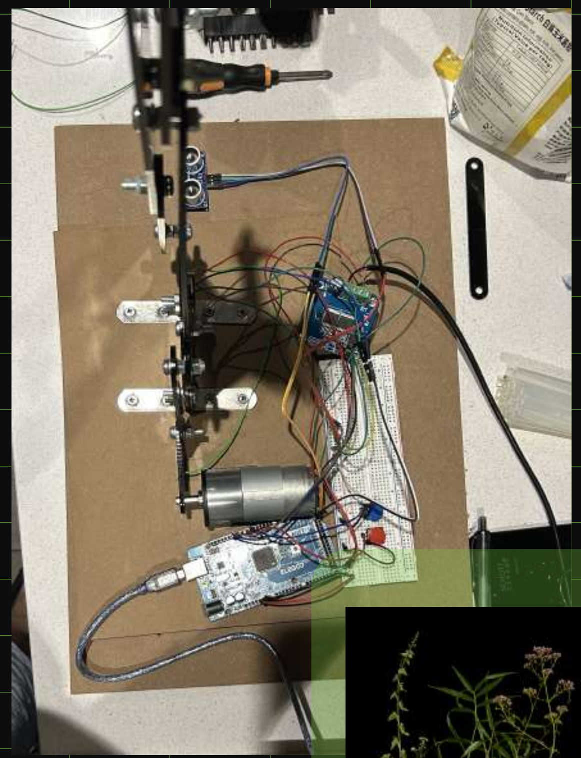
Discipline and Punish - Michel Foucault

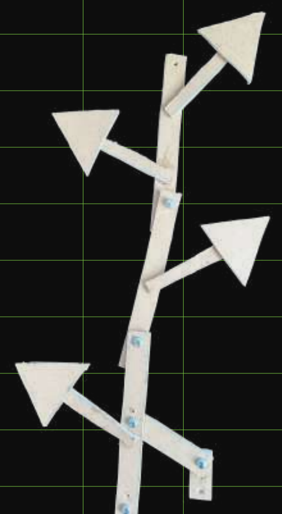
This led me to Michel Foucault's idea of the "docile body." In Discipline and Punish[1], Foucault writes: "A body is docile that may be subjected, used, transformed and improved." For me, this idea is important because control does not always look violent. It can happen through small actions, repeated practices, correction and ideas of what is considered "normal" or "better".
I was also inspired by Pierre Huyghe's Untilled (2012)[2], which creates an environment where humans are not fully in control. Plants, animals, insects and other non-human elements develop within the environment and create their own relationships. Huyghe's work made me think about the difference between controlling nature and allowing nature to exist by itself.
These ideas became the background for Good Plant, where I continue to question the relationship between order, care and control, and ask who has the right to decide what is "good" for another living being.

Technical implementation

I started by making a small prototype with cardboard to test the basic movement of the plant. I did not know much about mechanics, so I watched tutorials and learned how simple linkages, joints and motors work. After the cardboard model worked, I rebuilt the structure with 3 mm black acrylic and used M5 screws as moving joints. The main challenge was that the motor was too strong and sometimes broke the acrylic parts. I solved this by changing the position of the motor, making the connecting parts stronger, and using a longer linkage to spread the force. I also added limit switches to stop the motor at the two end positions. For the interaction, I used an ultrasonic sensor to detect the movement of the comb. Each interaction moves the plant one step, from 0% to 25%, 50%, 75% and finally 100%. I used Arduino to control the sensor and motor. After many tests, I adjusted the motor speed and movement time to make the movement slower and more stable. Finally, I added moss, leaves and a mechanical flower to make the structure look more like a plant while keeping the mechanical parts visible.







Reflection and Future Development

Making Good Plant taught me that a simple idea can become quite difficult when it becomes a physical object. I spent a lot of time testing the motor, joints and structure, and I learned that small changes in the mechanical parts can make a big difference. If I had more time, I would make the movement more smooth and accurate, and improve the sensor so it responds more naturally. My tutor also suggested developing the work into a garden with many different plants, all connected to the same system. I think this could make the idea stronger, because instead of controlling one plant, the audience would see a whole group of plants being shaped by the same rule. In the future, I would also like to make the plants move in slightly different ways, so the "garden" feels less like a group of machines and more like a controlled living system.

PIctures on the screen

0% 25% 50% 75% 100%

Reference

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Exhibition Photographs